

An aerial photograph showing the cleanup of the Exxon Valdez oil spill. Several large oil tankers and support vessels are positioned in the upper left, with yellow containment booms extending from them across the water. A large, irregularly shaped area of dark, viscous oil is visible in the lower right, surrounded by the yellow booms. The water is a deep blue, contrasting with the dark oil and the yellow booms. A pink circular graphic with a white border is located in the upper right, containing text about the spill's extent and cleanup time.

**The Exxon
Valdez oil spill
affected 1,300 miles
(2,100 km) of
coastline and took
around 3 years
to clean up.**

The ropes pass through the skimmers on the ship, which squeeze out the oil to be collected in tanks.

The ropes are made of materials that attract the oil floating on the water's surface.

Oil floats on top of water, because they don't mix well.